

THE STRATUM METHOD

Lesson 5 · Strata 05 · Resource 2 of 3

THE DRAMATURG'S METHOD

*A four-stage technique for locating the want,
the need, and the fault line between them.*

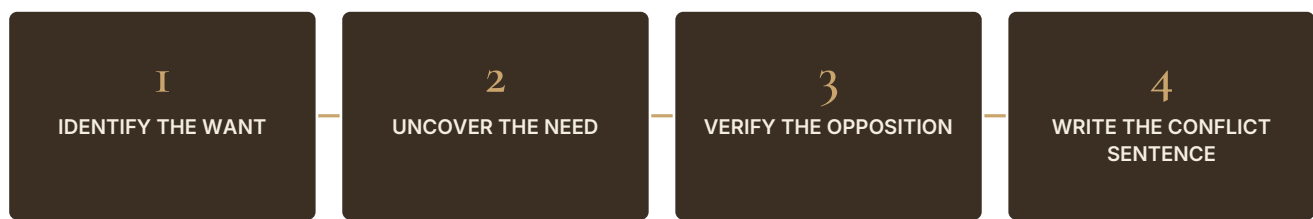


The Dramaturg's Method

A dramaturg is the person in a theater or film production whose entire job is structural: not writing the scenes, not directing the actors, but reading a script and asking the two questions that determine whether it works. What does this character want. What do they need instead. Every note a dramaturg gives traces back to whether those two answers are precise enough, and whether the gap between them is actually driving the story or just sitting there unused.

That is the job you are about to do on your own manuscript. Resource 1 gave you the two definitions. This resource gives you the technique for finding both — a four-stage method that moves from your character's stated goal down to the psychological strategy underneath it, then out again to what the story must supply, then back to your Lesson 1 instances to confirm the whole structure holds weight.

The Method at a Glance



Each stage below includes the question you put to yourself or your character, and a worked pass using Katniss — the same figure carried through Resource 1 and the prior four lessons — so you can see the technique land before you run it on your own draft.

1

STAGE 1

Identify the Want

State your character's primary plot goal, then ask: what am I really pursuing when I pursue this? What internal state would achieving it produce? Push past the first answer — if it could be satisfied once and be finished, it is still the goal. Keep asking what the goal would prove until the answer stops being an event and becomes a standing condition the character is trying to maintain.

GOAL

Survive the Games. Protect Prim. Bring down the Capitol.

PUSHED ONCE

"If I survive, it proves I can keep the people I love safe."

PUSHED AGAIN — THE WANT

To guarantee, through constant vigilance and self-sacrifice, that no one she loves is ever helpless because she failed to protect them.

2

STAGE 2

Uncover the Need

Return to the lie from Lesson 4. Ask: given exactly this lie, what would my character have to receive or become for it to stop running their behavior? Rule out wishes — "someone to love her," "peace" — and hold out for the specific experience that would require the lie to be factually wrong, not just less urgent.

LIE

"I am the only thing standing between the people I love and destruction."

WISH (REJECTED)

"She needs someone to take care of her." — too vague; doesn't address the lie directly.

THE NEED

To trust that others are capable of caring for themselves and for her — to allow herself to be protected, and discover her worth isn't conditional on being the last line of defense.

3

STAGE 3

Verify the Structural Opposition

Open your Lesson 1 PDF and take one of your three documented anchor-behavior instances. Walk through it and ask: how is the want operating in this exact moment, and does acting on it move the character further from the need? If the want and need could coexist in that instance — if your character could do the anchor behavior and still receive the need at the same time — the opposition isn't structural yet. Return to Stage 1 or 2.

INSTANCE (LESSON 1)

Katniss volunteers as tribute in Prim's place.

WANT IN MOTION

She removes any possibility of relying on someone else — she becomes the sole variable standing between Prim and death.

NEED BLOCKED

By taking full control, she forecloses the one thing that would let the need in: evidence that Prim, or anyone, could be safe without her constant intervention.

ON TESTING STRUCTURE, NOT SENTIMENT

David Ball — Backwards & Forwards (1983)

Ball's technique for reading plays works from the ending back toward the opening, treating each scene as a structural cause of the next rather than a self-contained mood. The same discipline applies here: don't ask whether the want and need feel different. Ask whether the want, enacted, structurally forecloses the need. A feeling of difference is not evidence of opposition.

4

STAGE 4

Write the Conflict Sentence

Combine both into one sentence: "Pursuing [want] makes [need] inaccessible because [one clause]." If the sentence needs a second sentence to make sense, the want or need is still imprecise — return to the stage that's loose and tighten it before moving on.

CONFLICT SENTENCE

"Pursuing her guarantee that no one she loves will ever be helpless makes it impossible for Katniss to receive proof that she is safe to need someone, because every act of control confirms the belief that she is the only protection available."

NEXT — RESOURCE 3

Resource 3 is a field guide to the four ways this method goes wrong mid-session — organized by which stage above produced the failure, each with a worked correction.